

*March 5, for Pippy*

I am so frustrated this moment. I almost used a cuss word for accentuation, but I will withhold. I slept well last night (and that's a blast), but I am already squandering the day away, getting dragged by my surroundings. This blend of lethargy and nervousness is never without awareness that time is passing without me getting to my business.

The love of my life is a great friend for frolicking, but not that good a one for frown. She used to be one when I knew her first. I miss the sensitive side of her. But for a while now, a "while" that could well be measured in years, I have felt alone. Every conversation with her where I address this, I return feeling unheard and guilty. She is convinced of what can be paraphrased as the problem being me ... "anxious, complaining, beating-her-down, depression-inducing" etc. It is not hard for me to be convinced of the same for I hate myself.

There are moments when I look at her face and her remarkable beauty and intense lightness overtakes me, and I do ask myself, why should she have any other business but joy ... should any bit of that breathtaking countenance be wasted on sorrow, and is it not true that sorrow is my sole contribution? But are you truly a *person* without sorrow? Not that she hasn't seen sorrow, in fact, she has seen it in heaps. But it appears to me that she is not keen to share mine. Yet ... what do I know, as I have twisted the folds of reality over and over again, with incessant sin and lies. The only *real* thing that I can whisper in my mind and with my tongue is the Jesus prayer:

*Lord Jesus Christ, son of God, have mercy on me a sinner.*

I have already failed at this *lent* endeavour. I have skipped days. I have barely prayed for others. I have turned this into a channel for fury and brooding. Lord forgive me.

This prayer is for Pippy, our dog. I don't think "our" is an overstep here. I love Pippy, although I feel disrupted by her at times. Pippy, truly speaking, fascinates me. In many ways she is an animal ... for example, her loyalty to us doesn't surpass her loyalty to food. Of course, this is not a volitional characteristic. Now, in some ways she is also a *person* (what is even a person?) Pippy reminds me of Mr. Skimpole from *Bleak House* — a man blind to every concern, lost in himself,

without awareness; rash, childish and frequently a nuisance. I hated Mr. Skimpole even more than Tulkinghorn the antagonist. But I absolutely love Pippy, for such nature suits a dog.

You could be admonishing her with yelling, and her tail would still be wagging, for it is her axiom that she is loved and wanted all the time. You may be amidst something very important, and Pippy wouldn't hesitate to scurry through the furniture, tread on your devices, and scratch your hands and demand to be loved, right there, right then. For it is her axiom that you love her supremely. Every time you eat she is convinced that you would spare her something, even if on the previous hundred occasions she was left wanting. If you accidentally hurt her, or scold her, it wouldn't take her two seconds to return and long for your touch. Neither is she slow to express her utmost satisfaction at a simple belly rub. The old, regular belly rub, somehow fresh and equally potent for her every day, like the morning mercies of the Lord.

Something about that satisfaction is *final* ... it is *restful*, again, in a "final" sense. God's children speculate much about the final rest, about the sheer "distantness" of heaven, how it doesn't only elude our experience but also our imagination. Heaps of pages of intellectual output of theological giants dedicated to articulate even a speck of the coming kingdom. And then there is Pippy ... common and poor, exhibiting some approximation of that elusive finality, at the plain sight of God's cynical children.

Pippy is not human. She doesn't live in the moral universe. Yet somehow, Love permeates out of the moral universe, and stretches abundantly over creatures like her ... who not only recognize it, but also participate. My little girl is a theological conundrum. An expert at *faith*, at adorableness. An expert at life. God bless her.

She has suffered much lately, sicknesses have struck her, one after another. Not a month after recovering from a gland removal surgery, she currently has a urinary tract infection. I pray that God will heal her soon. I pray that God would allow us to love her heartily, for her to gleefully enjoy her life. In the precious name of Jesus, who is Love Himself, the lover of mankind and of all creation, Amen.